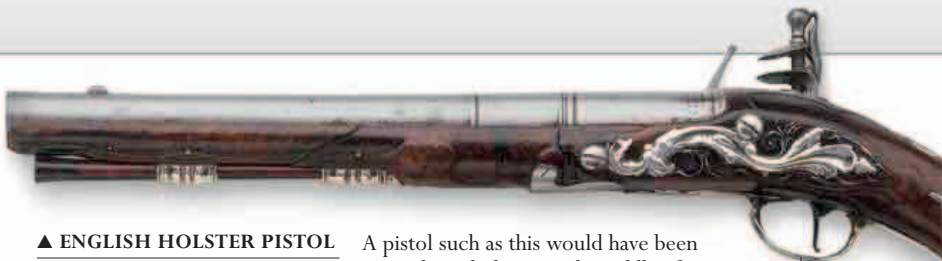




FLINTLOCK PISTOLS

(1701–75)

During this period, decorated silver mounts and the occasional use of inlaid wire became common on pistols for private use, while military pistols were still handsome pieces but rather plain. Although nearly all guns of the time were loaded through the muzzle, some pistols were breech-loading weapons, made with barrels that unscrewed for loading at the breech, which could be quicker and easier.

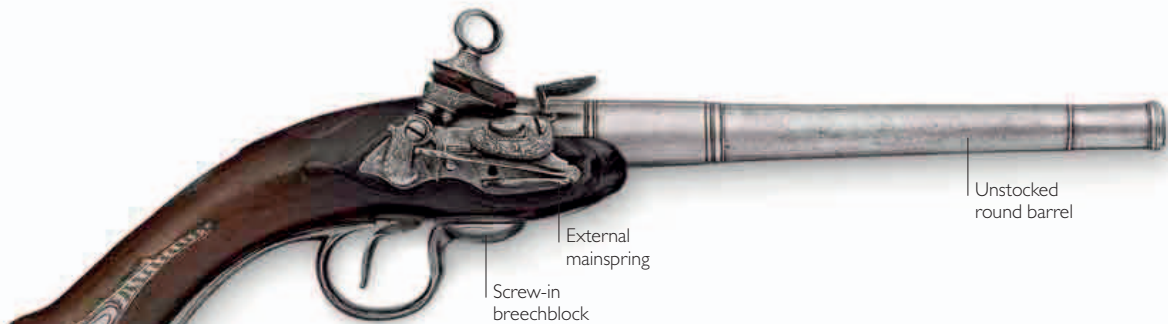


▲ ENGLISH HOLSTER PISTOL

Date	c.1720
Origin	England
Barrel	10in (25.4cm)
Caliber	.64in (16.2mm)

A pistol such as this would have been carried in a holster on the saddle of a horse (gun holsters worn by people were later inventions). After being discharged, holster pistols were often used as bludgeons.

Trigger guard



▲ SPANISH BREECH-LOADING PISTOL

Date	c.1725
Origin	Spain
Barrel	10in (25.4cm)
Caliber	.55in (13.9mm)

The miquelet lock, like the flintlock, had a combined steel and pan cover. But its mainspring, which powered the cock, was external, while that of a true flintlock was inside. This miquelet lock pistol is unusual in having a breechblock that screws out with one full turn of the trigger guard to which it is attached, allowing the ball and powder charge to be inserted.

Unstocked round barrel

Lock plate

Cock

Trigger has lost decorative finial ball at its tip

Silver medallion set into butt

Flint-clamping screw

Frizzen

Trigger guard

▲ WILSON PISTOL

Date	c.1730
Origin	UK
Barrel	5½in (13cm)
Caliber	.59in (15.1mm)

Robert Wilson was a maker of fine pistols during the 18th century. His firearms were sought-after collector's pieces and of the sort used by the famous highwayman Dick Turpin. Paired pistols were usually either for dueling or came in a boxed collector's set.